

A Web of trust

I am reminded of years ago, when security issues for websites became a major concern leading to the formation of companies like Verisign and Thawte (incidentally, the money from Thawte helped create Ubuntu).

An alternative mode of verification, modelled on the way humans trust each other, was proposed. If you trust a group which trusts a site, you trust the site. This is obviously extensible, as you can trust a site that is trusted by a group, which in turn is trusted by a group that you trust. So here, you have a 'Web of trust'. Obviously, it is more complex than that. Check out https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Web_of_trust for more details, including the issues and concerns associated with the model.

With the success of blockchains, a decentralised model like the 'Web of trust' may become a convenient and viable alternative now. For example, rebooting the Web of trust is an interesting possibility (<http://www.weboftrust.info/>).

Email as the link

Some years ago, BSNL forced changes in email IDs on its users, and I was unhappy. I believed that the single lifetime ID offered by Google was a saviour. Now, as I think about this, I wonder what I have done!

It was far too painful to create and maintain different email IDs. Hence, most of the sites know me by my gmail ID. This makes it far too easy for data miners to create a profile of me for whatever goals they may have. Even though Google sites and Facebook sites are not related, it is easy to link the data as Facebook knows my email ID.

One of the very useful features of email from the early days was the concept of an alias. The external world knew of a simple email ID, which could be forwarded to the appropriate person. The same concept could be extended to individuals. What if you could create aliases for your email ID and use a different alias for different sites.

You can do that even today, by creating multiple email IDs and forwarding the mail to a common ID. You could set it up to delete the mails from the secondary email accounts after forwarding. Although there is the nuisance of having to create passwords for multiple accounts, I wish I had thought of it in the light of the recent misuse of people's Facebook data.

Final thoughts

Security can be visible, like a person surrounded by police vehicles with policemen holding terrifying guns. Or it can be like the understated kind provided for western leaders. You know the security men are around but they are virtually invisible.

We do not want security to be so complex that even simple operations like transferring a small sum of money become a pain. However, we are no longer living in small villages, at a time when there was no need to lock one's front door. We need to make sure that we use processes that do not leave so wide a public trail that criminals can target us with ease. **END** 

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March 2018	Databases management and Optimisation
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August 2018	AI, Deep learning and Machine Learning
September 2018	Open Source and IoT
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